

Course of Theology, Volume I — Book VI On the Theological Virtues, Question XXIX: Whether Faith is discursive?

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QUESTION XXIX.

Whether Faith is discursive?

It seems that it is not, first. Because a habit which is not compositive is not discursive; since discourse takes place through the comparison of two extremes with one middle term; and this comparison cannot be made except through mental composition. But Faith is not a compositive habit; because its object is most simple; seeing that the first revealing truth, which is in itself most simple, is its adequate formal object. Therefore the habit of faith is not discursive.

1. Faith cannot infer through discourse either an act of faith, or of science, or of opinion. Not of Faith, because this is conceived freely through the command of the will, as was said above; whereas the consequent follows necessarily, the premises being posited. Not of science; because in this there is a clarity not pre-contained in faith. Not of opinion; because in this there is an uncertainty which cannot be derived from faith. Therefore faith can infer nothing through discourse.
2. If Faith could discourse, it could be the principle of a false act; because the intellect would not be directed in the disposition of the premises by divine revelation concerning that same disposition, to be made thus or otherwise; and the intellect can err wherever the revelation of God and the evidence of the thing are lacking to it. But the consequent is impossible. Because Faith is a gift of Grace, and no one uses a gift of Grace badly, as Augustine says.

Art. 1. I reply. It is certain that the formal object of faith is in itself most simple: since it is God himself, than whom nothing is, or can be conceived, more simple. It is again certain that our mode of judging, while the soul operates dependently on the body, is essentially compositive and divisive. For he who operates dependently on the Phantasy as it were reads, and gathers into bundles, the characters scattered in it. For it is necessary that he first apprehend simple and incomplex terms, which can be subject and predicate, and then, comparing them with one another, or as it were comparing them, he bears a judgment joining one with the other, or removing one from the other. Therefore the act of faith is most simple on the part of its motive; but composite, or rather compositive, on the part of the knower, and from the mode of knowing.

Art. 2. It is similarly certain that discourse intervenes in the work of believing. For since neither the credibility of the things which we believe by divine faith, nor the obligation of so believing, are known per se, it is clear that a discourse is necessary, by force of which both may be concluded: since they are not known through faith, which they precede. It is again certain — what was already indicated before — that the first act of faith cannot be inferred by force of any antecedent discourse, through a consequence whether evident or probable: Both because it would thence follow that the act of faith is evident, or probable, which appears impossible from what has been said; And especially because the formal object of the consequent is indistinct from the formal object of the premises, or at least is adequately contained in it, whereas the formal object of faith is distinct from the formal object of all the other cognitions of the Wayfarer; nor can it be adequately contained in it, as is clear from what was said above. Which reason equally proves it of every act of faith not presupposing in the premises other acts, or another act, of Faith.

Art. 3. It is certain, finally, that acts of Faith can discharge the office of premises for inferring another truth not formally foreknown through them. Which is clear, first, a posteriori. Because it is familiar to Theologians to assume principles known through faith alone, in order to infer various consequences. Next, because faith has a compositive and divisive mode of knowing, as was just shown; and hence it has the fitness for constituting discourse which the other cognitions have. Therefore Faith is discursive, at least actively; that is, it can be a premise illative of some truth,

Art. 4. It is now asked whether the act of a consequent inferred from two premises of faith, or from one of faith,

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and another natural, is an act of faith; or rather of another species? For the clarity of the matter, and to remove the equivocations to which it is liable, as Vasquez notes 1. disp. 5. Three things are to be held diligently before the eyes. First: God's concept of any entity, according to some predicate, is indivisibly a formal and express concept, and not only a real and material one, of the same, according to all and each of its predicates: Because it is a comprehensive concept. Whence God cannot manifest his formal concept of some predicate — and consequently neither interpose his authority for its truth — without manifesting his formal concept of all things identified with it; and consequently, without interposing his authority equally, and in the same manner attesting, so far as of itself, to the truth of all of them; although the exterior manifestation and interposition can be formal with respect to one, and purely material with respect to the rest. Which does not so happen in man, as being able to know one thing formally without formally knowing the other things identified with it.

Art. 5. Second: Every divine cognition knows, and affirms, itself to be true; because it is comprehensive of itself, and is true; and hence it knows and affirms that there is nothing by which it is falsified. Which is the same as to affirm the truth of all those things which are necessary for its

own formal truth. Because the exclusion of falsifying things cannot be made except through the opposite truth. Whence it is concluded that God's formal concept of some objective truth is indivisibly a formal concept of all those things with which it is essentially connected, even though it be really distinguished from them, no less, or otherwise, than if they were really identified with it, concerning which was the preceding notation.

Art. 6. Third: a cognition inferred from another cognition, or other cognitions, and a cognition essentially dependent on the inferibility of its own object from the object of the same cognition, or cognitions, differ widely from each other. Because the motive, at least partial, of a cognition inferred from another cognition, or other cognitions, is the connection of the object to which the inferring cognitions are borne with the object to which the inferred cognition is borne; nor can the opposite happen, as is clear. But a cognition essentially dependent on the inferibility of its own object from the object of other cognitions, that is, on the connection of one object with another, can have a motive distinct from that same connection. For it will be able to be moved by the same motive by which it is moved to assent to the object whose connection with the other is known; provided the motive be such that it can equally move immediately to the assent of both, the cognition of the connection between the two being posited. And indeed that it is not the same to know the connection of one with another, and to infer one from the other, is clear. Because God knows evidently the connection of creatures with himself; and yet he does not infer the cognition of himself from the cognition of creatures; and we can know that something is revealed, and that the revelation is essentially connected with the truth of the things revealed, without on that account actually assenting to the truth in reality revealed, on account of the revelation. Nay, we cannot assent to it on account of the revelation, according to what was said above, if at the same time we have a demonstration of the same truth.

Art. 7. It must now be said to the question proposed. First, that a cognition inferred from premises, whether one natural and the other of faith, or both of faith, is not an act of faith, but of another species. Because its adequate motive is not the divine authority alone, as is clear from the third notation. But it was said above that the adequate motive of an act of Faith is the divine authority alone.

Art 8. It must again be said that a truth evidently inferible from two premises of faith, or from one of faith and another naturally metaphysically evident, is certain from faith, and can thereby be believed by divine faith, nor can it be denied, per se speaking, except by heresy. Which is clear, because he who denies something, by that very fact dissents totally, or at least partially, from all the motives able to infer its truth. Therefore in the case posited, he who denies the inferible truth by that very fact dissents from the truth of the premises. But it is impossible that he dissent as to that part which is evident, and is known through the evident premise. Therefore he dissents as to the other part, which is certain from faith, and is known through an act of faith. But he who denies a truth which is of faith is a heretic. Yet it can happen per accidens that that truth so inferible be denied

without the aforesaid connection of the article of faith with it being adverted to in act, or being evidently known; and then there is no heresy. But that the same truth so inferible is by that very fact affirmable through an act of faith — whether it be really identified with the truth of the premises, or really distinct from the same, and most of all from the truth which terminates the premise constituted by the act of faith — is proved. Because by that very fact that truth stands under the same divine concept under which stands the truth formally revealed, and the same divine authority is interposed equally for both, as is established from the first and second notation; And hence both truths have equal credibility through divine faith for him to whom is evident the connection of the truth revealed formally, and in its proper terms, with the truth not thus revealed through a revelation public and common to the whole Church. Which, however, is to be understood, according to what was just said, provided the cognition of that connection have not the character of a premise actually inferring in the consequent the term of the connection; but only the character of one proposing the same connection, and of a condition *sine qua non*, with respect to the act by which the intellect assents to the same term of the connection.

Art. 9. Hence it follows that all and each of the propositions, whether particular or singular, whether wholly determinate or indeterminate, evidently metaphysically contained in a universal proposition formally, and in its proper terms, revealed, insofar as thus contained in it, are of faith: Which needs no special proof beyond that which was just given. Yet a certain distinction is most of all to be observed. For if that containment of the Propositions, whether particular or singular, is publicly known and intimated to the whole Church, to which whole Church likewise the universal proposition has been revealed and sufficiently proposed, then propositions of this kind pertain to the public, Catholic faith, common to the whole Church. But if either that containment or that revelation is not thus public and common, the same propositions will pertain to the private faith of each; for in this second case the particular and singular propositions stand altogether in the same way as revelations made to private persons, and with arguments of credibility only with respect to the same: Now although private revelations of this kind can, and ought to, be believed, when sufficient arguments of credibility are present, by a divine faith of the same species as the faith of the revelations common to the Church — which to Card. de Lugo and others rightly seems altogether certain, on account of the identity of the formal motive, whatever some may say to the contrary: Nevertheless the faith of a public revelation is of a far different character from the faith of a private revelation, as to its external profession, as to the contentious forum, and some other effects, the discussion of which is not of the present undertaking.

Art. 10. From the distinction given it is again inferred, in particular, that it is not of faith that under these-in-number accidents of a consecrated host the Body of Christ the Lord is present, that this-in-number man baptized or ordained has received baptismal grace or Priestly power,

and so of other things of this kind: But that it is of faith — and indeed public and Catholic faith — that this-in-number man, e.g. the present Innocent X, is the Supreme Pastor of the Church, and Pontiff, and universal Vicar of Christ, and legitimate successor of St. Peter; that the things defined and declared by him as of faith, and proposed by him as such, are truly of faith; and so of other things pertaining to the supreme office and power of the Supreme Pontiff.

Art. 11. The reason of the former part is, that although it is of faith that a host duly consecrated is converted into the Body of Christ, and that the Body of Christ itself thereafter remains under its accidents; yet it is not of faith that this-in-number Host was duly consecrated, with the due and necessary intention, and with the legitimate power of him pronouncing the words of consecration, nor are sufficient indications present concerning this, such as to make an evidence of credibility. And, what is the chief point, the revelation made to the Church, concerning the conversion of a duly consecrated Host into the Body of Christ, is not rendered false or useless, nor is the intention of God revealing it frustrated, even though one or another Host which appears duly consecrated, and is proposed as such to be adored, be not in reality consecrated; since in the many others there subsists the effect of the conversion, vaguely and indeterminately signified through the revelation of God; and thence is gathered fruit, as great as was thence efficaciously intended by God. Let the same discourse be made concerning the other examples of this kind.

Art. 12. The reason of the latter part, conversely, is: that since God, as the Catholic Controversialists lucidly prove, has revealed to his visible Church that it shall endure perpetually, and that the gates of hell shall not prevail against it; and moreover that it is built upon the rock, which is Peter; and that to him has been committed the office of supreme Pastor and head, for feeding and ruling the flock of the faithful: Nor can these things subsist, unless the successors of Peter perpetually endure with the same power of feeding and ruling, as the Church perpetually endures, which can neither endure visible without a likewise visible head, nor be sustained, fed, or ruled visibly by a man removed from the living: it is plainly manifest that those divine revelations cannot be true, and that the divine intention sufficiently and patently signified in them would be frustrated, if this-in-number man Innocent X were not the true Pontiff, universal Vicar of Christ, and legitimate successor of St. Peter in office and power. For it is most manifest and most evident that there is no visible head of the likewise visible Church fit for ruling and feeding the faithful, if such is not he who is acknowledged as such concordantly by the whole, or nearly the whole, multitude of those same faithful. For neither can they be directed or fed visibly by one who is not acknowledged by them as universal Pastor and Rector; and no other is now acknowledged as such, but Innocent X himself alone.

Art. 13. From which reason it is clear, moreover, when it begins to be of faith that this-in-number man elected for the time is the true and legitimate Supreme Pontiff of the Church. Namely, when the whole, or nearly the whole, multitude of the faithful is seen to assent uniformly to the legitimacy of the election; or when already so many, and such, have assented, that it cannot prudently be doubted that the rest will come to the same opinion, the circumstances being inspected which become known

in the place nearest to the election. For no more fitting proposition of this article either is given de facto, or can even easily be given, or devised, acting conformably to the human condition, and in a human manner, to which divine Providence accommodates itself. Wherefore the remaining articles also, for this same reason, then obtain internal illumination and proximate supernatural credibility, and begin to be of faith, as to the proximate obligation of believing, when there has been applied exteriorly a proposition sufficient of itself, with respect to each one, for prudent human credibility; although human and natural faith itself in the articles is not necessary for conceiving divine and supernatural faith, nor is it in any way compossible with the same, as is evident from what was said above concerning the supernaturality of divine faith, and its impossibility with opinionative assent. It is concluded therefore, consequently, that in the present matter the divine faith of the Supreme Pontificate, conferred on this determinate man, is preceded by the supernatural apprehension of the natural assent of the rest, joined with the arguments of credibility of the divine universal revelations, which were premised in the proof of this part.

Art. 14. It must lastly be said that acts of divine faith can discharge the office of a premise in a syllogism inferring a false consequent. Because although truth is essential to faith as to the complexion of the terms of which it consists; yet not as to either of them separately, and according to itself, since any one of them separately is indifferent to truth and falsity, just as it is indifferent to being joined to another incomplex term, whether congruent with it, or not congruent. Whence, an act of faith pre-existing, another natural proposition can be adjoined, composing either of the simple terms of faith with another simple term which does not agree with it on the side of the thing; and so the proposition turns out false, and fit of its kind for inferring a false consequent: yet not on that account can the falsity of the consequent be formally attributed, even partially, to the act of faith: because the formally adequate cause of the falsity in the act of the consequent is always that proposition which joins with the middle term a predicate of itself repugnant, or repels from the same a predicate connected with the same; which in the case posited the natural premise alone would do; and therefore the act of faith would stand to the falsity purely materially, in nearly that manner in which God stands to the character of the malice belonging to an act which is sinful, and as a sound and straight leg is compared to the limping caused by a crooked leg. In so many ways, therefore, faith is discursive without any inconvenience.

Ad 1. Just as God and an Angel know objects in themselves complex and composite without composition on the part of the cognition; so it happens to us, conversely, that the things which are in themselves simple we know only by composing, or dividing, on account of the noted dependence of the intellect on the phantasy, which compels it to represent simple things after the manner of composites. For which cause it is necessary that faith too compose, or divide, while it enunciates — not indeed by affirming a composition, or division, holding on the side of the object in itself simple; but by representing it after the manner of a composite thing.

Ad 2. A consequent evidently inferred from a double premise of faith, or from one of faith and another evident, is called knowledge had through Theological demonstration, and Theological science. But if one of the premises is not certain, or the inference from a double premise certain in itself is inevident and uncertain, the consequent is called Theological opinion, and can be false — the cause of the falsity, however, being only the premise which is natural, as has been said. Whence it is clear that a sufficient enumeration of the parts was not made in the objection.

Ad 3. It has already been said that the falsity which is in the consequent proceeds formally, neither adequately nor inadequately, from the premise which is an act of faith: Whereby ceases the inconvenience deduced in the objection. Because no one uses badly that thing to whose use the evil which follows cannot be formally ascribed.